40 TRADING SECRETS I WISH I KNEW 5 YEARS AGO

Hard-earned lessons to fast-track your trading journey and start thinking like a pro.



SAM SIDNEY

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Introduction:

Welcome to "40 Trading Secrets I Wish I Knew 5 Years Ago" If you require additional support you can contact me in the Financial Hideout Discord channel. You can click the hyperlink or find the invitation in my Instagram bio.

Additionally, for a beginner to advanced trading guide created to teach you how to become a profitable trader and escape the rat race, see my e-book using this hyperlink for a discount.

When I first got into trading, I was overwhelmed. Charts, strategies, risk management, psychology, it felt like there were a million things to learn and no clear roadmap.

I made every mistake in the book. I chased setups. I overleveraged. I let emotions run the show.

But over the past five years, I've learned what actually moves the needle. Not the hype. Not the flashy indicators. Just the real stuff, the kind of principles and systems that consistently separate successful traders from the ones who give up too soon.

This guide isn't just a list of tips, it's a collection of hard-earned lessons I wish someone had handed me when I was starting out. Use it as a blueprint to build smarter habits, avoid common pitfalls, and start thinking like a real trader, one who treats this like a business, not a gamble.

Let this be your shortcut to wisdom I gained through years of trial and error. If even a handful of these secrets shift your mindset, improve your trading, or save you from a big mistake. I've done my job.

Let's dive in.

The Mindset Shift:

1. Consistency beats intensity.

One good week won’t make your career, but showing up every day with discipline will.

2. Trading is about probability, not certainty.

You won’t win every trade.

Learn to think in terms of long-term edges, not individual outcomes.

3. How you respond to a loss is what defines you.

Losses don’t mean failure, they’re feedback.

Review, adjust, and keep going.

4. Treat trading like a business, not a lottery.

Track performance, manage risk, and aim for sustainability, not overnight wins.

5. Avoid trading to 'make money.' Trade to make good decisions.

When you focus on execution over outcome, profits become a byproduct.

Mastering Your Mind:

6. Your emotions are a signal, not a weakness.

Fear, greed, hesitation, they're all telling you something.

Learn to observe, not react.

7. Journaling is non-negotiable.

Data on your behaviour, setups, and psychology will become your greatest edge.

8. Most traders lose not because of their strategy, but because of their discipline.

Execution and emotional control matter more than technical skill.

9. Let go of FOMO.

If you missed it, it wasn't yours. There's always another setup.

10. Positive habits prevent negative results.

What you do daily shapes your account and your outcomes.

Risk & Money Management:

11. Always define your risk before the trade.

Never enter without knowing your max loss.

This one rule protects your whole career.

12. Small losses are the cost of doing business.

Don’t fear them, embrace them as part of the game.

13. Don’t over-leverage.

Scaling up too early ruins accounts. Only increase size once you’re consistent.

14. Use a rule to lock in green days.

Example: If you’re up 3R, stop trading for the day or protect at 2R.

15. Keep losing days smaller than winning ones.

Example: -0.5R losses, +2R wins = long-term profitability.

Building Systems:

16. Systems beat opinions.

Have a rule for everything: entries, exits, risk, and daily limits.

17. Rate every setup.

Only risk full size on A+ trades. Grade them and be strict.

18. Use time-based levels and sessions.

NY Open, London Killzone, and Asia highs/lows often mark key moves.

19. Have rules for scaling out.

Trim into strength. Lock in partials. Avoid regret.

20. Use data to refine your edge.

What setups perform best for you? What times? What conditions?

Learning from Experience:

21. You don’t need to win more, you need to lose better.

Proper loss management keeps your account alive through drawdowns.

22. Journals reveal hidden patterns.

Study them weekly to make smarter decisions next week.

23. Review > Rushing.

A daily trade review builds skill.

Skipping it costs you long-term.

24. Don’t scale until you're bored.

If the trade feels exciting, you're probably risking too much.

25. Failure isn’t the end, it’s the start of the next level.

Every setback holds a lesson.

Stay in the game long enough to apply it.

Developing a Sharp Edge:

26. One high-quality setup is better than five random ones.

You don't need to trade every day — you need to trade the right days.

27. Build a "trading playbook."

Collect screenshots, journal entries, and ideal setups.

Study your winners and losers until the rules become second nature.

28. Know the market conditions your strategy thrives in.

Does your system work in ranging markets? Trending? High-volatility sessions?

Trade only when conditions fit your edge.

29. Think like a sniper, not a machine gunner.

Precision matters. Patience for the right shot always outperforms constant pulling of the trigger.

30. Mark session highs/lows before trading.

Knowing where liquidity lies helps you anticipate where price is likely to go not just where you hope it goes.

Systems, Structure & Rules:

31. Limit the number of trades per day.

More trades = more emotion, more fatigue, more mistakes.

Protect your mental capital.

32. Use a daily risk cap.

Example: Max 2R per day. If you hit it, walk away.

This prevents a bad day from becoming a blown account.

33. Have a process for losing streaks.

Drop risk size. Stop trading for the day. Review past trades. Don't double down emotionally.

34. Build trading into your routine — not your entire life.

Obsession burns you out.

Systems sustain you. Create a daily routine and stick to it.

35. The only thing you can control is how much you lose.

Accept this fully, and your trading will shift overnight.

Thinking Like a Trader:

36. Prop firm accounts are tools — not lottery tickets.

Use them to scale your consistency, not chase instant payouts.

37. Copy trade only after your strategy is proven.

Earn your funding. Then automate and scale.

38. Don’t switch strategies mid-drawdown.

Your system doesn’t stop working just because you’re uncomfortable. Stay consistent.

39. Use lockout features and withdrawal goals.

Prop firms give you tools to protect your account. Use them.

Don’t rely on discipline alone.

40. The goal isn’t to trade forever, it’s to build long-term freedom.

Think bigger. Stack prop accounts. Withdraw wisely.

Build the life trading was meant to unlock.

Final Thoughts:

Trading isn't just about entries and exits. It's about how you think, how you manage risk, and how you handle yourself when things don't go as planned. The traders who make it are the ones who build systems, track their data, stay disciplined, and keep improving—even when it's tough.

These 40 insights aren't just rules—they're habits, beliefs, and systems that took me years to learn the hard way. My hope is that this guide gives you a head start and helps you avoid the most common mistakes new traders make.

If you're serious about growing as a trader, go back through this guide again. Pick a few points that stood out. Reflect on where you're falling short. Then build a plan, and execute with purpose.

You don't need to be perfect. You just need to be consistent, intentional, and obsessed with improvement.

Now go apply what you've learned. The version of you a year from now will thank you.